

Thomas Metzinger ~ Active Inference Insights 021 ~ Pure Awareness, Self-

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hello everyone and welcome back to
active inference insights I your host
Daris parv Wayne and today I am truly
honored to be speaking to one of this
Century's most important philosophers
Professor Thomas metzinger Thomas is
Professor emiritus of theoretical
philosophy at Johannes Gutenberg
University of Minds co-founder of the
German effective altruism foundation and
president of the barbar vengera
foundation in 2019 he found founded the
minimal phenomenal experience or MP
project and just this year released the
book The Elephant and the blind which
details the results of that project
bringing together more than 500
experiential reports to offer the
world's first comprehensive account of
states of pure Consciousness his work
focuses on Consciousness and he is best
known for establishing the self model
theory of
subjectivity Thomas Professor matzinger
we've we've spoken on email we've had
our sort of you know we've had our email
friends but it's actually so lovely to
to kind of see you or be it virtually um
so thank you so much honestly it's an
absolute honor and anyone who knows me
knows that I'm a massive fan of yours I
mean in the latest version of the flow
States paper it has met singer 2003 2004
2005 2 and so on yeah something wrong
with you thanks for having me anyway no

well well it's one of those things I mean with respect to your work I feel like the past year has been sort of half active influence half met singer um so recipe for disaster but let's look at it no no it's why it's being fun I mean let I think a good place to start for the audience is to kind of out before we get into the new book because I do want to touch on that is to First outline the self model theory of subjectivity the smt because um it might strike people as initially rather counterintuitive so perhaps you could just give a brief account of the fundamental um claims or axioms of the smt with respect to its kind of key constraints whether that's transparency globality and so on yeah so in the Anglo-Saxon World there is this absolutely unreadable 2003 book um being no one this actually has a precursor most of you will not know in the German system we have two major thesis we have a PhD thesis and 5 years later we have a habilitation thesis which is a much bigger thing my committee was 17 people wow and in 1993 I published a book called subject on self model um sub the subject and self model and the subtitle was the perspectival of phenomenal States from the perspective of a naturalist theory of mental representation so this already tells you what this is actually about um so being

in the Consciousness Community I'm one of the guys that founded the ASC in 1994 I was always of the opinion that Consciousness is not one problem but a whole bundle of problems some more empirical some more conceptual and that the center the most difficult uh thing is what is a first person perspective what makes a state a subjective state in any given information processing system so I set out to tackle this and then 10 years later I had um a wonderful year one of the two best years in my academic career at UC San Diego where uh Paul and Patricia Churchland had hosted me was absolutely great in the philosophy and the cognitive science department and I wrote the whole thing in English and updated it in that year in the eighth floor of the HSS building Humanities and social sciences and I thought you can't do that title Americans need something more crude yeah yeah I said call the book being no one and uh that is what you have now uh and the idea this is indirectly it's also trying to make a contribution to the problem of Consciousness but the idea is to say what is a first person perspective really because everybody in Neuroscience or in philosophy talks about for instance like Dave Traas would be One PP facts and three PP facts but the notion of a first person perspective is taken as a conceptual primitive as if we all knew what that is but um it's actually a

hybrid metaphor so you have the first person pronoun and there is a lot of good work in analytical philosophy of mind on you know if there's some irreducibility in um indexical expressions like I myself that's so that's so to speak the linguistic the surface level and perspective is a term from another discipline geometry you know people who work in Geometry can tell you something about what a perspective is parallel lines meet in infinity and and so on and so forth but together you know one could say it is the epistemic perspective that a system gains if it can refer to itself in the first person singular if it can use say an expression like I by saying I'm particularly happy and relaxed right now ascribe a phenomenal state to itself but then this would exclude all systems that can't use language all higher vertebrates and animals and well I developed we we can go what I really think a first person perspective is I think it's a model of the intentionality relationship maybe we can come back to this later and in my own to make the connection to active inference so I'll I'm much older than you are I'm 66 years now for me the first really first big intellectual Revolution was to discover Anglo-Saxon analytical philosophy of mind and get out of this Continental swamp I grew up in you know in the

Frankfurt philosophy department and I'm
very grateful to the older
philosophers um people like Peter beiri
and so forth who is already already died
um who
poisoned young German philosophers by
importing Anglo-Saxon analytical
philosophy of mind where we discovered
wow you know we've had this military
catastrophe and everything in the
century but in other places on the
planet philosophy has gone on you know
we just had total Destruction in in our
country for decades and lost our
intellectual Traditions teacher disciple
relationships
so I I really went into analytical uh
philosophy of mind uh that's one thing
another thing is taking conscious
experience really
seriously um because it was kind of
ignored by mainstream
Neuroscience a third element is um
opening analytical philosophy of mind to
neuroscience and cognitive science to
organize interdisciplinary
cooperation and then maybe the second or
third um really intellectual revolution
in my life was um connectionism and
neuron networks and uh you know this you
have and Clark um micro cognition
1989 uh in your country was super
seminal and important for us and early
work of Paul Churchland also and
subsymbolic representation you know this
whole debate photo compositionality and
all this was very
interesting and when car came out in

2010 um I've made a decision for myself
that I'm too old that I'm not I'm just
not going to get go into this on a
formal level so when I in for instance
the 2003 book use the term
model mental model uh it is not a
model in that terminological
framework so as I say in the prease this
is all just introduction to the self
model theory of
subjectivity the first inspiration I
mean of course Roots Run deeper but um
there is a book by Philip Johnson L that
was called mental
models um about relational data
structures and there's a tradition in
theories of mental representation in
into which we looked very deeply in
German philosophy maybe 20 years ago we
discussed very deeply different models
of mental representation and their
history and there was a
guy in 1943 Kenneth Craik who wrote a
book the nature of
explanation and there you have for the
first time that's the classical Locus
for the notion of a model a mental model
relational data structure that have a
partial homomorphy to the Rel
know structure of what they represent so
that's where the term self model came
from me there there's a lot of technical
stuff there diagrammatic reasoning right
how how can system think with image like
structures and not with symbol calculus
you know that's where it comes
from
and step

one I think there three major steps
maybe step one was to apply this to
conscious self
representation and say okay there must
be something like a phenomenal self
model Beyond you know linguistic
representation by mental models the
whole technical Universe
there
um the second thing is the notion of
transparency which
actually originated in your very own
country with GE Moore uh to apply this
to the idea of a phenomenal self
model um and ask what would happen to a
system if not the external model of the
world were
transparent meaning could not be
experienced as a
representation if it could if it
operated under a model of itself a
global integrated model of itself that
was transparent which the system itself
could
not um experience as a representation as
an internal
representation and then the third
step is what does it
need in addition to do these two things
to gen generate a consciously
experienced first person perspective
because you can imagine some systems
human beings who are say completely
conscious Wide
Awake who have a self model say a robust
body
model say some states of stupor or total
absent-mindedness or something like this

but who do not have a subjective per
perspective on the world in any
interesting sense at least they don't
experience they may have one in
epistemological Reading but
phenomenologically they are not directed
to the world as knowing sells and what
what is the difference there and um well
I think it's that systems like us even
model the intentionality relationship we
can postpone that um so there I try to
construct a theory a naturalist Theory
how something like consciously
experienced firstperson perspective
could have naturally
evolved what else do you
think listeners should know about the
self mod so the main point is everybody
thinks this is a theory of Consciousness
no the aim was to have a cons an
experience of subjectivity yeah yeah
okay so so okay the thing is there's
plenty there's plenty and I think um in
my experience is that the the Notions
have been developed uh chronologically
in some ways like I sense there's a
focus in your work towards uh the
epistemic agent model the epistemic self
model in the sort of 2013 2014 meding
Gary and stuff yeah yeah but I want to
go all the way back I think a really
good place to start for people in my
experience was the prey to being no one
which is this 2005 paper um so there
there you talk about simulation and
emulation and I think that's a nice
place to start which is that in self
models we have a emulating an emulating

and simulating system and a Target system and it just so happens in the self model those things are the same and so I've always thought about with your work the kind of notion of a strange Loop or recursivity such that there's a part of our information processing system that is targeted at itself such that it simulates and by simulates you mean um reflects or uh the output of the information processing system and emulates the properties and states of that information processing system now I don't think people will necessarily have an issue with that right this goes all the way back to uh cybernetics con good regulator theorem I guess what people might say is okay I have a model of myself and I in the sense that model is embedded in a world model so I'm also doing the same thing with respect to uh the world why is it that that process C of simulation and emulation is giving rise to phenomenality why is it giving rise to subjective uh experience and if we can pass these two things out the what it is like to be a conscious being so why again it's it's a hard problem question but I guess um yeah yeah yeah I know what it's worth asking just to get R to the nuts and bolts what is it about that simulation and emulation act well so I think a simulation if I if I first generate a simulation of you I will

simulate observable properties that my
receptor systems what I can see and hear
of you your my my visual representation
of you my auditory representation I can
simulate that then I can discover that
you have
unperceivable invisible features too
namely that you are also a
simulator and I might simulate those
properties of you psychological
properties mental properties if you want
to put like a which are not observable
by this kind of sensorium this kind of
animal which I am has so I can in mind
reading for instance human beings can
simulate each other and they can emulate
each other now the interesting thing is
the reflexive
case I can have a body model that's
trivial and I can also somehow simulate
abstract properties of mine that's where
it already
gets interesting
like are there
actually I mean there's the inceptive
self model but that's receptor
based what are these mental properties
of myself for instance I may take myself
to be a person I live in a culture in a
society where we know the status of a
person and I know this and then somehow
I represent myself as a person as a
rational individual that would be a very
high level
emulation now does any of this need to
uh be conscious I don't think so that's
um that's the million dooll question of
course um I think that the largest part

of the human self model is unconscious and the question is what is if we take the global workspace metaphor as a like as a proxy for a theory of Consciousness what part of the self model this organism has is currently globally available what part of the self model for instance can voluntary attention be directed to and what can you not direct your attention to what is what part is available for Selective motor control to which parts of myself can this itself can this animal point and I think most of the knowledge the really robust knowledge is of course unconscious so what your colleague George Dean would call the homeostatic control model which I think George has this very nice differentiation between an allostatic control model and a homothetic control model I think that's very useful and making those different levels in a human self model more precise and of course most of homeostatic control is totally unconscious um you know breath heartbeat blood body temperature and in a sense that's a self model but it's not a phenomenal self model and what is that part that needs to be elevated to Global availability what are the so to speak the functional the neurocomputational properties that any given moment Mark out the phenomenal partition I have no

answer to this but uh I think that's the research question so I don't think that you magically um like pull yourself out of swamp by having a strange Loop trick of self- referentiality and then the lights go on you become conscious um as I've tried to demonstrate for people who didn't know it in that new book um non egoic selfawareness without a firsters perspective is a widespread phenomenon that we know Consciousness can experience without a phenomenal self and Consciousness can exist with a subject object distinction without any experience of being directed as a knowing self as the world these are not necessary conditions so it might be something entirely itself I have wild speculative ideas but nothing I could really argue for yeah I I I will I definitely want to get into that um I I guess a point of clarity for people is that um would should the So when you say that when when it's written that the emulating simulating system and the target system are identical is to mean that they are uh strictly identical in the sense that if we took the neurocognitive mechanisms right if we just went to the physical level they would be the same or do we think that there's a higher order Network in uh organisms that possess a self model that

is solely reserved for the act of
simulating and emulating that's an
interesting question and that that's
where it gets very tricky um so
I think of course I think the phenomenal
self model uh that is currently active
in your brain right now is strictly
identical with some physical subset of
your brain properties probably it's best
be described on a functionalist level as
a computational a Time slice in a
computational um process so it's
not identical with you as a whole with
Darius as a whole um the idea is rather
from an epistemological perspective the
subject is the organism as a
whole to achieve knowledge conscious
knowledge about
itself that organism has developed a
neurocomputational tool that tool is the
phenomenal self model but that's
physically of course that's just a part
of its nervous system
physically so it's like the whole
organism kind of refers or represents
the whole organism consciously through a
special part it has a physical part so
in if that picture is roughly right um
then saying they are
identical is is not true it's it's like
the epistemic subject what has that
conscious self knowledge and the
intentional object that what it is
directed at that's identical in both
cases it's the organism as a
whole but the tool that's being used is
something in its brains only a physical
part I don't does it make things clearer

or is that confusing um no I think it makes it clearer for me

um God knows who it makes it clear for

um I guess people all might also be thinking especially if they're uh neuroscientists let's say that all that exists in the nervous system is are these electrical signals uh in which there is no inherent distinction between the self and the world absolutely there's just sort of zeros and ones

let's say how I mean does this require another computational mechanism to do the distinguishing I mean as you know this is a classic problem in cognitive neuroscience and Phil of mind right like the So-Cal self specifying process yes is there something about self modeling because maybe this is worth explaining as well that the self model is always embedded in a world

model is there a way in which the system that's emulating and simulating itself does not take itself to be the whole world because if it you know the whole world is almost encapsulated embodied within the nervous system such that it can be phenomenally represented how does the system managed to make it distinction between itself and its lived world that's very important and a lot of things need to be said there

um maybe as kind of a preface

um we have to distinguish levels of description for instance a self model as described on the representational level

of description which something which has
a content and the content is the
system as a whole or a self model that
is described on some functional level of
description say more fine grain
computational level of description by
the causal structure uh and um that will
be some computational process uh in the
nervous system and then of course at any
given moment there will be a
neurobiological

implementation and there's a whole story
which I exclude for now about inter
subjectivity and social environments and
and all of
this

and in making this distinction over the
years I've I've these distinctions I
found a very important one that gets
many people confused is
um the um the

distinction between a computational self
model and a phenomenal self model so
there's this intuitive notion ah thisy
is talking about the ego and what I
experience as myself the egoic
phenomenal self model there are special
cases where it's not entirely like that
but in general oh yeah what I I'm this
thinking walking body controlling
feeling self that's a phenomenal
phenomenal self model we have quite
often during waking

States now if we look at the
computational self model model then
technically and we just look at
conscious
representation exactly what you said now

is right all of the world which I now
experience as being external to me is
technically an internal State it's a
virtual model it's a prediction about
what might happen next on many different
levels so what it actually is is as I
said in my popular book the ego tunnel
it's like the walls of the ego tunnel
it's like a surface but not a
two-dimensional surface a very high
dimensional membrane or Surface in that
model with colors objects sounds and
stuff like this and um in that in that
respect it's a holy internal Affair and
the puzzle consists in so if this is all
an internal process why is it so robust
ly experienced as the environment as the
external uh reality of the system how
does it make uh that
distinction
and one aspect is what am I the obvious
cause
of as you have written yourself you know
what what is the the domain which is
highly predictable and which I can
control that's a
candidate uh for what becomes the self
model but computationally and if we just
talk about Consciousness thing the whole
thing this whole room the screen with
your face my face that's a self model
because it's a
prediction of likely own States um that
may it's an anticipation you know uh so
in that sense it is neither that's also
interesting it's a probability
distribution in that sense it's neither
real nor

unreal it is that's what I mean by
virtuity you know it's strictly speaking
it's not
real it's all a massive very complex
hypothesis at every uh single moment so
how is this so
fundamentally
split first thing to say I think is
is we have especially in the
light of say the last 10 15 years of
theorizing get away from this simplistic
self-world
otomy if this whole story about Markov
blankets and so forth is true there are
many nested Markov
blankets uh and there are many
statistical boundaries a living system
creates for instance in its unconscious
self-organization and Elementary
bioregulation
internally uh to the to the organism
but I can well imagine that in this
active inference framework when I
actually do change something in the body
external world and try to make the world
conform uh to some internal Target state
or something
um there must be
one really well defined No Nonsense no
woo woo phenomenology Feelgood stuff
where in saying that the human self
model pulsates across the boundaries of
the organism you know it sometimes
dynamically runs Loops uh through the
environment
and I think it would be a major
achievement if we could say all this in
a formally uh precise way yet all the

time I'm a very old-fashioned guy it I think it remains true that phenomenal properties locally super on neurofunctional properties in the brain that what is consciously experienced even in skillful embodied interaction with the world is fully determined by local neural activity in the brain you know even if the system develops a complex causal Loop through the environment conscious experience the phenomenality as such is locally constituted locally generated identical uh to a local process I would say and if that is true we might in the end arrive at a situation where people say ah Consciousness is so uninteresting you know it's just you know no but then these larger bubbles so bubbles they might be theoretically much more interesting maybe than that local model in the brain last thing let me just last I have often ask myself the question you just put to me what is the origin of self models asked people I mean and I think a really good candidate dat is the immune system um it's a lowlevel very lowlevel process and it's super efficient you know we develop more than thousand malignos cells every day and your immune system shoots every single one down every day else you wouldn't be here it's a very old process it's very complex it's not localized in the nervous system but this um process is one of the first processes I think

that draws a boundary between this is me
and this is not
me there are even even people who speak
about an immune
self and
uh I think out of these entirely
unconscious
processes of trying try to maintain the
boundaries of a living
organism this is where it slowly grew up
grew out of you know from a molecular
level and
um then of
course did you come to the in the new
book did um did you come to that notion
of the single embodiment
constraint no I haven't okay there's a
and then I working my way slowly through
it yeah lot of people presently do um so
uh this is something I want to point out
because it's a constraint which
is so simple that most people Overlook
us Overlook it we human beings most
animals are beings where all effectors
and sensors are located in a narrowly
circumscribed space of physical space
space location in physical space we have
a single
embodiment we have a single skin surface
pretty well defined we are highly local
beings we could
imagine um an artificial intelligence
which has become conscious which
administers
administrates a few thousand robots with
s and effectors or uh of their own all
over the planet on the surface of other
planets that AI could look through the

windows of many single embodiments local
embodiments of
robots without actually itself having a
single embodiment it could develop a
very different kind of self model or
mental properties than we have but we
are just these local entities so for us
it's very obvious physically localized
in a single
embodiment all almost you know sensors
and effectors all concentrated in one
location in physical space so the body
model the physical organism model what
can it do where can it climb how fast
can it run this would also naturally
have been something with a pretty simple
boundary in space
and so on and so forth I'm just trying
to point out logically this wasn't
necessary there could have been
completely different intelligent
creatures somewhere else in the
universe widely distributed or something
yes it's a fault experiment that I guess
um is in some sense uh impossible to
conceive because of the boundedness of
our perspective perspective that's
interesting isn't it well maybe it isn't
I mean maybe I can't I mean I've been
reading a little bit of Peter Godfrey
Smith um B the pop science on octopuses
octopodes and he speaks a little bit
about these kind of you know the fact
that octopuses seem to have um a far
more distributed cognitive system which
could imply multiple self models you
know one for each
arm I think what's interesting here is

that thus far everything you said would be highly convergent with the with the Fluffy continentalists so um get we'll get there because um as I as you know I'm very interested in these kind of self- specifying processes yes so this is the work that really blossoms out of Dorothy Ion's really wonderful sort of five years which he's just writing these incredible articles about self-specifying processes and thus far I think you know what you're saying makes perfect sense which is that you know her and Evan and um others have said you know one of these self-specifying processes will be these efferent reafferent

Loops uh and that is self self-specifying because the cognitive system in some ways recognizes a signal that's caused by its action and a signal that's caused by the world yes and then the other thing interestingly is actually in that 2011 tiex paper um specifying the self for cognitive Neuroscience they also talk about something akin to what you were uh mentioning with respect to the immune system which is that homeostasis uh might itself be a self non-self um specifying function absolutely because it's a self that's um maintaining its Integrity over a precarious world now the tension I think lies in this self as subject self as object distinction okay uh and this is where I you know this is where I've really been digging in and and trying to really get to the let's go there if you

want to well I I I only briefly want to touch upon it because I think that Iron would have an issue with this notion that at its very bare minimum what you would call the minimal phenomenal selfhood what she would call the self as subject or pre-reflective self awareness can be representational yeah rather she would propose that and I think people like Dan Harvey and Shan Gallagher and going all the way back to SRA and moo Ponte that these are just uh this is just the subjectivity that's imminent in all experience yeah and it structures the world which it intends if that makes any sense um how can you main so how can you get pre-reflective self-awareness self a subject uh and keep your representationality uh how how do you make those two marry this brings up I'm going to share an anecdote with you so many years ago Francisco Varela you know and all these guys they have these this dogmatic dogmatic thing they don't know what they mean when they talk about representationalism but they know representations are bad and it is something rigid a represent and a representat and it's a rigid relationship and it could never be alive and all that so Francisco Vila invited me and David Chamas to um Paris to give talks and then he listened to myself talk and and he came to me afterwards and he said Thomas everything you say is

Absolut right I can
subscribe to everything but you're
totally lost as as long as you don't uh
give up your
representationalism you yeah you're
doomed and of course this is nothing new
they all say that but what they haven't
properly followed this intellectual
tradition is I mean the concept of
representation has developed veloped
over some 350 years and and people you
know dick hard Mal bran and people have
thought about it and I think only a very
small uh part of the Continental
phenomenology tradition have
even grasp uh neural networks and the
fluidity and context
sensitivity of neural networks and
dynamical systems and all this stuff we
cognitive science has been through um
representations can be
something very much alive and super
context sensitive you know and uh it's I
think it's very obvious that our concept
of representation is evolving if you
think you know um of the whole
predictive processing framework how it
is evolving but personally I'll just
tell tell you what my personal uh stance
on this is the representational list so
I'm an instrumentalist and but not a
realist about representations I make no
statement if anything like that exists
in the world met physically all all I'm
saying is at this stage of scientific
progress wherein last 40 years maybe
modern cognitive science the concept of
representation which is being

continuously enriched and calibrated and refined uh you may remember that in being no one you know I talked about presentation representation simulation all that is still useful it is still juristically Fant to use that level of description but there will be some stage in scientific progress where we probably discard this uh and and say okay now let's say a cards model goes through somebody will say okay it's now all a part of statistical physics or something like this we Notions of content uh of Notions of a belief or Notions of a model how ever technically refined is not something we need anymore we can do it all on a lower level of description and I mean the super frightening question is of course if this could happen to phenomenology itself you know to Consciousness yeah people would eliminate that concept because they have more fine grain lower level uh concept so I'm not wedded to the representationalist level of description but I still things and that brings us back to our conversation also I still think um it is very useful for instance speaking in terms of models and self models still and say well now we mean something more predictive processing is by it and not something Johnson Lish by it yeah although one can see if one looks there's an intellectual tradition there

this is not

disjunct right so

MPS

um yeah you know

there's I should shouldn't say much

because I haven't properly read that

literature but there is this it has the

MPS paper in 2009 was very influential

and then people have made their own

naively realistic branches of it and he

kept talking of the minimal self and a

minimal self as if there was a

thing and

maybe I don't know if that's relevant

but one also has to be aware that this

whole issue of self is of course

ideologically

charged um there will be a group

whenever you say something about your

ideas Darius there will be a group in

your audience who are Buddhists and say

yeah yeah yeah yeah yeah no self I've

always wanted to be you know and there

will be another group who has a strong

desire for mortality denial and there

something that is irreducible or some

ideological things so um and it cannot

be true that there is not something that

is Untouchable by science or by

philosophical analysis for many people

that's

emotionally very important and that puts

a lot of noise on the signal for

instance

I think most of the criticism and re uh

react uh resentment I've got in my own

country in

Germany was not by you know Catholics or

people who want a metaphysical notion of
self but by very good leftists who
thought this is dangerous because it
erodes the Revolutionary
subject and they didn't read you know
but you know the idea
sure they didn't read it properly they
didn't understand these things but they
said this is kind of dangerous we need
the rational critical subject the
subversive subject and yes good luck um
well I just don't well my well I I mean
that sounds almost quite Catholic in
some sense that you're invoking some
kind of cartesian uh thing onto itself
that that can make itself
revolutionarily and subversive I'm I'm
in some sense interested in a far more
stripped down form of selfhood such that
I don't even like using the word I'm
more interested in subjectivity okay I
guess no no and it's totally fine I mean
I mean um there's a I just think for
people there's a nice very nice Stanford
encyclopedia article by zahavi and
Gallagher about self-consciousness and
there they kind of talk about how
deflationary we should take this notion
of pre-reflective self-awareness to be
and I'm quite interested in this very
sort of to the point where the notion of
self itself kind of disintegrates such
that you're left with as I said the
subjectivity imminent in experience I'm
just curious in your when you write um
that sorry footnote before you go on
yeah I of course know this article I was
always much too lazy to submit one of my

own but this article uh in in the SCP is
is a political move it's very clear that
it is a political move to establish a
certain view on on self-consciousness
and exclude
others it's not very balanced and of
course there is would you agree and I
understand this of course I emotionally
understand it do you under agree that
there is an anti-reductionist resentment
in this there must be
something you know that's un Noble
Untouchable um perhaps perhaps I'd have
to go and read it more with with respect
to that question I have to go read it a
little bit more acutely I mean I'm
personally I mean maybe this is the
product of being an early career I mean
I'm not even in a career but let's say
like an early level researcher that I'm
quite Keen to remain agnostic about the
big questions um
interesting well also because I don't
want to piss people off um and who am I
to piss off you or Dan Harvey or Sean G
right we all no no we can we can all be
friends um I think that said I mean in
terms of the sociology of Consciousness
I think there is been a slight push back
against I think you're right there's
been a slight push back maybe for
ideological reasons and I think some of
it probably is something like Terror
management um against the iru against
the reducibility of
Consciousness I I I think that's
certainly true I mean I'm recognizing
even in the conversations I am having a

far greater willingness to invoke at least for hypothetical reasons something like dualism and that's interesting um again I'm quite agnostic I think that I won't say that Consciousness is reducible and I won't say Consciousness is irreducible um I guess I take I I'm not I don't know about the ontology and I also um and my my my limitations with the ontology in many ways the limitations of my epistemology right like I it could be it really could be that it's all neur networks and neural firings um I just don't know and so I'm quite happy to remain silent where I where I don't know I guess the question I was going to ask is you say that um the content of experience is representational content and I'm just curious about whether you would say that pre-reflective self-awareness so the sense that is not intended but is there that experiences for you is a content of experience uh it's um it's well it's never really clear what pre-reflective means you know there's a lot in German idealism in fact we have our own local discussions of this with people like d Henrich and so on what this pre pre element really is in which everything is grounded and it's in what sense is it pre is it that what comes first when you come to after birth is it in a temporal sense pre reflecting about yourself as a subject or is it something deeper is it some

transcendental a condition of
possibility for everything
else if that's or is it because the
condition of person uh possibility
itself will not be something phenomenal
this will not be something you
experience but I
think there may be an interesting way
out there that some creatures can
internally represent the conditions of
possibility
say for having a first person
perspective but of course not in words
concept or
propositionally but in an entirely you
know Subs symbolic format this
is the enabling condition for things
more complex States I will have
later and
um the the question is I think your
question is would can or do we want to
describe this as a
representation I mean if it is something
that is if the claim is this is
something everybody can consciously
experience I mean this is somehow the
claim you all know this pre-reflexive
element Um this can of course be
doubted like you mean the same thing
when you refer to it and dorot means the
same thing and I mean the same thing
of my
attempt has always been to go deeper
than that or make that more precise I
pretty much know what they mean and it's
a long broad tradition from from satra
and so forth and German idealism fish
and all all that um but what is it

actually to take it seriously and not
just keep saying as a placeholder pre
reflect
so the real German term
is and that in English means something
like pre-reflexive
self-intimacy there's a way of being
intimate with
yourself way before any thoughts or
concepts appear yeah that's what I'm
also interested in uh and I don't know
if you would agree but being self
intimacy is is an epistemic notion
somehow you know
yourself somehow you are always already
in touch with yourself you know
and I've been
um you know
very interested in what the sources of
this are and I think if you look at it
there's more than one source actually so
for instance
I don't know the French um so in in Malo
ponti has this point they take this
distinction of
um body kper Cara by the way relates to
the English word corpse know that's the
inanimate body and the lived body and um
Malo ponti made a very interesting point
about what in German is called
that
means means there is one signal Source
in the self model which is
permanent something like the proceptive
self model and the inceptive self model
which is like the background hum of your
refrigerator which is so invariant that
you don't hear it anymore until the

refrigerator goes off and there is something in the phenomenology the interior perception of One's Own body um that has permanence and I think that permanence is responsible for some of the cartesian intuitions that not only you have but that I have too because I think in English you say a substance uh is ontologically self-subsistent I think I think that's the the right term you would use sounds about right yeah so a substance if the self was a substance it would be something that could hold itself in the state of existing even if everything else in the universe would disappear that's a metaphysical substance now we find that in our phenomenology I think this experience Maro ponti pointed to is it's an experience of not only being very deeply intimate and in touch with myself but continuously holding myself in existence and what I find so fascinating this is exactly what Carl talks about when he speaks about predicting yourself into existence we are actually yeah maybe you guide me I talk no it's just I no no no that that face was only because I've been reading so much L and she's obviously influenced me um met no I haven't I mean I I sort of I would love to I haven't even reached out to her um this is this has just been like it's been a bit of a whirlwind of me just reading her papers and being

like Jesus Christ um I think I think in part because in the British educational philosophical curriculum you're taught that Consciousness involves necessarily qualia intentionality and subjectivity and so for someone to reinforce the uh subjectivity aspect I I don't you know it's like I'm flirting with objective Consciousness and subjective Consciousness and maybe it's just it was a nice reminder you know it sort of spurred up some childhood memories for me of learning about Consciousness okay I'll I'll I'll throw two things at you about cartesian intuitions um I have them too and intuition is something that gets in your way when you do philosophy because it is something that structure structures your model of reality now the human self model has a specially extended part the body model and it has layers which have no special properties namely if you do um if you calculate in your head or something like that if you do abstract reasoning the phenomenology is you're doing it it's mental action but it is not in space it is in time so it has some parts of the self model are spatially coded uh on the level of phenomenal experience and some only have temporal properties that makes this car the cart's argument about *res extensa* and *res cogitans* extremely intuitive for beings like us for beings with self models like

us do you say
chimes resonates with our um
self-experience because we are indeed
sometimes thinking things and you've
written about it in your forthcoming
paper that when we mentally act we
automatically
imply that there is an entity uh that
can control in this way there's a
controller and of course the same for um
bodily movements
um so that's
why cartesian intuitions are so
plausible um they get in our way it
there is something
inconceivable uh in the truth of say
physicalism or subjectivity only being a
very high level irrelevant um
property and uh in in this Oxford
Handbook of the self I've I've written a
chapter called um the no self
alternative I try to
explain why everybody necessarily has a
feeling there is something
wrong with no self
scenarios because the very Act of trying
to actively mentally
simulate a possible World in which there
was no
self always generates a sense of effort
and that sense of effort is the self you
know yeah yeah yeah you you get my point
it's well well sure I I mean for me that
I don't I I wouldn't I don't know how
much metaphysical import I would draw
from that in that intuition um I
guess so it cannot sorry for
interrupting but cannot be true for

beings like us it cannot be true could
never be really
intuitive level right I think I think
that's absolutely right um well I guess
my question here therefore is at the
phenomenal level not the metaphysical
level okay um I so I want to talk about
your new book um but before I get into
that so in your new book you show
there's a kind of non- egoic zero person
perspective
um which implies that in some ways
there's a it was well again I haven't
read too much of it but it it sounds
like to me that you that one could
interpret that at least as the
maintenance of a world model without a
model yeah I'm curious about whether you
before we get into that what about the
inverse of that could you imagine that
there could be a self model without a
world model well absolutely I bring this
up so first
this new book which is open access
available for everybody uh the English
version um is not a scholarly monograph
this is not like being no one it's more
like a multi-level experiment in popular
signs so I'm trying to the the it's it's
really an experiment trying to inspire a
lot of very different people at the same
time which includes practitioners of
meditation who may not have no interest
in research uh or philosophers or even
theologians to offer something to take
it out of my hands so my ideal reaction
to that book would be if many people say
n nice try I can do this much better

that would be my ideal result if people
take these bits and teasers and do some
proper um research
somewhere now the question that occurs
of course the in the phenomenology of
mystical experiences non du awareness
there's a a cluster of phenomenologies
I'm trying to document
there for some
people the self
expands um for
instance it the phenomenology of
identification can attach not to this
body and not to The Thinker of these
thoughts but to the all pervading
quality of awareness as such um that's a
well documented phenomenon in advanced
practitioners of
meditation so you can become the
awareness but the question is there are
long
traditions in Asia who say that is the
true self like ad
vanta and there are long traditions like
all the centuries of Buddhist
philosophies philosophy will say no no
no there is no such thing as a
self and uh if you would now let's just
take speak
phenomenologically about the
phenomenology of
identification the kind of phenomenal
content of which you could after the
experience say I was
this because during the experience
you typically cannot say I am this you
cannot really say it right um
so that

phenomenology is there a phenomenology
of identification with the whole with
world or should we rather
say these states are um neither self
States nor World States you know because
the distinction doesn't make sense
anymore and you know there's this notion
of nondual
awareness in the contemplative
Traditions that there are states of
experience Global States modes of
experience in which uh the distinction
between subject and object makes no
sense anymore so I quote one Advanced
meditator from Israel at some place in
the book who says it is not me looking
it is the world
looking so that the whole world becomes
the epistemic subject The Knowing entity
or something and as you very rightly
point out we
have this becomes a terminological issue
some Mystics over the centuries will say
I became one with the world I still
wasn't there uh I still was there I
expanded all embracing others will
say um a description I very much like by
one person was nobody sitting on the
cushion everything sitting on the
cushion uh he described this you know
that like the whole world sits on the
cushion but he's not there all the heavy
um
so that's a terminological question
um the way I would like to frame it is
that what was previously the the egoic
phenomenal self
model can in some rare cases become

identical to the computational S self
model we talked about
earlier so so the whole thing becomes
recapitulated into sort of phenomenal
space yeah it's it but it's also as if
these states were much closer to the
scientific image of the world than the
old biological model of reality with a s
going through yeah yeah yeah no I mean
of course yeah yeah so absolutely in
terms of how neuroscientists take it it
absolutely is consonant with that I
guess my question here is again it comes
back to this pre-reflective versus
reflective dichotomy when we talk about
the possession that these people
experiencing uh expansive States Of
Consciousness Oceanic feelings of
consciousness at one month and so on are
we talking so it sound like to me that
actually The Possession in many ways is
a is a pre-reflexive property of their
experience such that uh the whole world
is seeing is not I am seeing the whole
world as mine yeah yeah yeah of course
not is there so I wanted to recognize
that there is a difference there because
I think um I've done a bit of meditation
not as seasoned as you or or someone
like lar but in some ways I found that
you know at those very glimpses of nonel
awareness there is a kind of very subtle
recognition that uh I would would the
sense that I am not distinct from that
which I am
observing but in some ways that so that
but that in some ways that is uh can be
paradoxically flipped to mean that sort

of I own that as much as I own
myself
um there's just two meanings really of
the word owning absolutely right yeah
correct and so I'm just curious about is
it really the case in all of these
So-Cal zero perspective the owning is uh
all you know emerges pre-reflectively or
is there also a split where the
possession is a reflective I own this
thing like I own my car or I own my
laptop I mean
afterwards this is also true for
psychedelic
experiences um afterwards people will
some people will just stay quiet
and not report this and keep it as a
treasure and most other people will run
off and talk about it and they will talk
about it in their belief system in given
the conceptual instruments their culture
their cult their spir you know their
linage their spiritual linage their
Master whatever their church has given
them and that is actually what I'm
calling attention
to this phenomenology is almost
ineffable and if we could make a little
progress uh bring a little Clarity in
there because it's so
obvious that there is an elephant and
different people describe that elephant
in different ways and can we make I
don't have the final Solutions can we
make some conceptual progress in
understanding this and
one thing that will fall out naturally I
think

is that what these
German
idealists
fish and um say people like Manfred
Frank and daa Henri in Germany would
call this pre-reflexive self intimacy
and what you have in this satra uh this
this whole story maloon uh tradition as
pre pre-reflective
self-awareness there's actually
something slightly below this or it can
be said more
precisely and I call it non- egoic
reflexivity because I think the really
really interesting Discovery the Tibetan
Buddhists have made I don't know maybe
in the 12th century or so is that this
experience of pure awareness
has a quality of reflexivity in it
sometimes but not always there's even a
term called
rri um self- knowing uh non- egoic
awareness and I think that is probably
the common phenomenological anchor for
what all these
philosophers try to home in on as
pre-reflexive selfawareness
but they do make the Mist
take of still putting projecting some
egoic character into it some yeah well
well my intuition you know and there is
no ego character in it yes is
there is there
perspectival I'm not the person to know
but person I take very seriously
is the world can be seen out of this so
there is okay this is maybe I don't know
getting too much but there is something

that is called dual mindfulness and meditation researchers research where you would say sit on your cushion and have an experience of pure awareness and it's all nice and clear and silent but you're still having it there's a meditator who has pure awareness yeah yeah yeah and then there is nondual mindfulness which is absolutely effortless no control therefore if my theory is right that the phenomenology of ownership is um called uh is caused by control controllability then it would not be going along with ownership as you said and uh I found it interesting sahav has at one point use that concept of anonymity also I think yeah something that is really in that sense nameless and self not owned by anyone yeah uh yes and my suspicion is every human being actually if they are a little quiet and silent and they feel into it they can experience this non- egoic reflexivity in pure awareness they know what this is but then later to describe it leads to an explosion of philosophical system yes and poetry no but no not in a derogatory way uh I I mean poetry in the most complimentary way um I thought that some of the testimonies of these people were very beautiful so I mean that not at all in a in a demeaning way to their experience but they you see they most of them are not economic academics and they don't read things like you and I read um it's amazing how they yeah yeah about

they do their best they do their best in
natural language but the sexy question
is of course if
given mathematics and computational
phenomenology we could go further we
could have more precise
descriptions maybe a perception in which
in the end
dor and TR galaka and everybody can say
yeah that was what we meant yeah Thomas
was right
no not Thomas was right no I know I know
but there's a the question is of course
what are the criteria can we
have any
criteria I mean what would convince
you in the end it's just people talking
about their own phenomenology right it
is and I wanted to ask about this
autobiographical retrieval aspect but
actually before I do I want to just ask
about this reflexivity because I thought
that was a very interesting point that
some of this egoic awareness non-ic
awareness rather is reflexive and some
isn't now it seems to me that again
there are multiple ways of
disambiguating the term
reflexivity
yeah so one is a kind of reifying
reflexivity um such that it becomes a
thing that you own right so um this is
my leg is clearly self-referential but
it's also reifying right I can sort of
dissect my leg as an object that belongs
to me uh and actually I think Dorothy
again is quite helpful here in her kind
of analysis of uh dancers talking about

their experience of their own bodies as performative and transparent rather than opaque such that they can take their body as an intentional object without reifying it through what she calls scrutiny so I'm curious to think about what it means for non egoic awareness to reflect on itself how can this be done in a manner which doesn't in turn rify uh the aware the the awareness itself pure awareness such that it sort of becomes an encapsulated notion that something is beyond so that has alterity with respect to something else that's a super interesting question and I'm I think you're just homing in on the Target and uh I think there's nothing you can do doing anything will always ruin it and as all meditators know if there's even the faintest Glimpse the noticing of this Glimpse very often ruins it um because it leads to the reification or some stray thought that says uh and as I quote one of our subject somewhere in the book who says very interestingly to me but is this pure awareness asks the thinking mind and something else just knows oh you know that's how she describes it right something else just knows because it knows itself and of course it's non propositional and I mean there's a long tradition I have a small chapter on meditation and non-meditation who have always said over the centuries there is nothing you can

do do not
meditate
uh one of the
nicest present day installments of this
is American meditation teacher I Kelly
there's a three minute uh YouTube video
which goes don't meditate
marinate the whole idea is
this is here it's
established yeah don't
the um try to grasp it or experience
it because it's it's already here um and
you have to if you can marinate in that
quality which in more sober words I've
called a phenomenal character of tonic
alertness I think it may be something
very B basal and very simple in the end
namely just the quality of pure
wakefulness as
such and if you don't attempt to look at
it
subjectively but like rather dissolve in
it marinate in it then maybe it can know
itself through you or something like
uh but it needs a lot of future research
and the big question is of course also
I mean what value do we assign to these
experimental
reports yeah many of these people are
deep into bizarre belief systems you
know they are way out of the scientific
worldview some of them will
not many but some of them will not be
accessible to rational
argument um and is that
well there are two things there one is
I'm gonna ask you something so if Doro
says in there's a perfect flow moment in

dancing where my body come becomes
transparent so the body would always be
transparent to use her word well apart
from something in like a deafferented
patient um by bodily transparency she
she doesn't really mean what you mean by
transparency as you actually pointed out
no that's different but
if she the way she uses the concept of
the transparent body yeah it's intuitive
to you you have the feeling um I I I
understand this notion of the world
being presented in a bodily fashion
aha that's really what she means so she
she there's there's multiple so this for
people who are curious is it's it's
actually it's her and who is the other
it's

2009 um

there it is perceiving subjectivity in
bodily movement LR and Raven R A VN uh I
think Raven also wrote a fair bit about
dancing um yes I think Dorothy was very
much on to what we're talking about here
in terms of flow States but she says um
let's have a look let me I just want to
make sure I don't take her words out of
you know out of context or or speak on
you know well I shouldn't be speaking to
paraphrase Vicken Stein um
but I will come to
it in any case um
footnote that there yeah yeah if you're
interested in all of
this um I would very much recommend the
work of Adrian
alith okay at um King's College are you
aware of him I'm not he wrote an

excellent thesis with me called the
structuring body yeah and this is all
about how the body structures the
perceptual field or the phenomenal field
Y and there's a lot you might be
interested in there cool well I
certainly well thank you I'll certainly
sent him I've just looked yes yes this
notion of structuring is is is an
interesting one I think I do understand
it but I'm also I'm also to some degree
concerned about how much I'm getting
indoctrinated by the um by the Poetics
of some of these papers such that I P if
I just need did a title perceiving
subjectivity I mean you can perception
is object representation subjectivity is
an abstract concept it
invites uh trying to build a mental
model of that uh of of of that sentence
while trying to understand it can I
perceive my own subjective
yeah I can and no scientist is ever
going to take this away from
me you
know what's funny is that you two you
two thank each other so much in your
like
footnotes I I I like her and she
always came as a visitor to the Mind
Group I think it's it's all very nice
but if you want to take it
seriously what does perceiving
subjectivity mean does this does this
make any sense conceptually well I think
I think to be fair I would take the
notion that that title is somewhat
tongue and not tongue and cheek but it

and it's it's certainly not lazy is
certainly the wrong word but it's
somewhat
um it's somewhat
deflationary uhhuh I think I think I I
like this notion more of Perce I mean
again I'm doing a rubbish job um but
it's very important I think to contrast
it with this with what she calls opacity
and what she calls
performativity um I think I may it may
oh it may actually be the uh the Iron
2007 pre-reflective self-consciousness
on being bodily in the world which was
in Jana's head um it's funny I've been
recommending these papers to everyone so
sorry guys if you do put down the garden
part you know and I recommend yours as
well Thomas obviously um
yes okay excellent um a transparent body
pre reactivity experiences the bodily
mode of givenness of objects in the
external

World

okay this is yeah so 20 what they mean
but I even say this in the Elephant book
very briefly givenness G height there's
the myth of givenness will willf fre
sellers the concept of givenness if we
want to take it really really really
seriously has strong theological con
notations uh there are philosophers
of religious religion who speak about
the quality of givenness as the world is
given to me my life is given to me by
God and all that sure if we take this
out Dar the letin
Darius the Latin means to give that's a

social relationship between person A and B so if you say there is a quality of givenness there there is an entity that has a personal level characteristic if I want to take that literally that gives something to me so the world is another somehow it is another self that reveals itself to me or gives it to me as a present

that's I mean that's poetry uh that's beautiful I I think I can

experience what is meant by this there are

phenomenologies but conceptually it doesn't really make sense there is not a giving something to person

B maybe it is much something much more like what the Buddhists would call the quality of suchness that there is a self-revealing quality in in in inanimate objects which you can perceive if you look properly or something like that that's

speculative so I know no other way of taking what Seer says

seriously as trying to take it literally and then it explodes in my head well I guess the idea might

be perceptual object I'm just very sorry you

know the idea might be

um the idea might be that um well okay so I will come to this notion of

perceiving subjectivity because I have the paper now in front of me I think in terms of the givenness I mean I think again I'm not a historian of phenomenology uh this is all you know

somewhat new given my age and whatnot
but um I think some of it seems to be a
linear AG from husel and this notion of
givenness and then I think the other
thing that feeds into it is and I think
it probably is protor religious in some
sense that it's intentionality or
Consciousness giving its own contents to
itself yeah and and then some ways it
speaks to you know God as the Divine
spark God as Consciousness and so on
which is obviously a deeply
judeo-christian
idea yes do you have any of those I mean
just also map on on some
predictive processing generative model
of reality in the brain right because
this is also self-giving all the time of
course it's confirmation bias in many
ways um it's confirmation bias
aha but well we seek we seek evidence
for the priors that are you know encoded
in our generative hierarchy I mean
that's that's the B if we Remain the
things that we are of course
um I wondered whether you know that's
that kind of claim that
intentionality I I use it you know I
think what we've kind of come to here is
the importance and in many ways the
opacity that language gives right when I
say in Consciousness gives its own
contents to itself I am constructing a
kind of subject verb an SVO sentence
which I could say for I eat a pizza
right but I mean something clearly quite
different here and I think in many ways
of course it it rifies the subjects and

the objects because that's language does
and and so as you say many of these
conversations end up being literally
ridiculous um because it's it's very
difficult to understand exactly what's
being spoken about here but I think
again there is a latent uh ontological
commitment in something like that which
is that uh Consciousness is in some ways
an agent has some agentic Force to it
that is not just a not just a uh a part
of its phenomenology but perhaps also
part of its

ontology again I'm very much this is not
what dor or Mur Ponte anyone says I'm
just abstracting here

somewhat you're you're I guess quite
Keen to bracket out those ontological
commitments right you this is not a
theory of Consciousness per se uh how
the simulation and emulation manifests
into phenomenal space is somewhat the
big question right it's traumas is hard
problem is there anything in you that
when you say there are no such things as
selves is there any part of you which
goes but I don't know because I don't
know the the the true origin of
experience yes of course I don't uh I
might you know die in five minutes and
no and there may be a roaring crowd of
angels laughing at

[Laughter]

me you know and and there may be all
these non-physical entities slapping
their knees laughing loud and saying no
look at yourself without a body it was
all wrong you know uh uh many things

could happen the next instant I I don't know

idealism might turn out to be right in the end there are these also probably there are metaphysical options I think which in principle may always remain viable and of course it and you can if you take the whole self model Theory which has many layers something we haven't spoken about for instance completely

is social self models self models in societies the resonating process between different uh subject you could turn it around and said if it allows you to sleep easily

this is a theory about what selves are self are intermittent processes that are absent in uh in dreamless deep I mean phenomenal self-d dreamless deep sleep which are very different and very volatile during the dream state the non-lucid dream state and which are sometimes on some layers are quite robust during waking and we know this and there probably like a self something like a self model and then if you look closer you find a that a lot of things you've always thought aren't true so a famous Point some meditators make if you actually attend to what is going on in your head and when you go about your normal business during the day you don't have to meditate there's very often there's no self there yeah well no absolutely absolutely well there's no uh it so depends on what you mean by

the self I mean there's no self there's
no self as what I call well you know the
self as uh what did we call it reflect
you know conceptual the self as a
conceptual object I mean again I get
into the Super granularity of this as
you know in the footnotes um I've you
know and people can read the footnotes
of that flow paper and I think it's an
attempt to really unpick if we hold this
dichotomy of self as subject to self as
object where does it uh linger and where
does it diminish and here your work on
mind wandering dreaming is super
informative um I guess the response
would always be well un you know
underneath all of that still yes the
loss of cognitive agency the loss of
autonomous agency there is nonetheless
the subjectivity imminent in experience
and I well the reason why I asked this
ontological question is I I one
clarifying question do you
mean underlying is a phenomenal
experience of a really primordial let's
say primordial
subjectivity or are you
saying the enabling conditions are
always still there I can always come
back I'm talking I I'm talking about the
former okay I think I think think if
there is
experience if there again I need I I'm
reticent to say it but I think if I I
well at least I take seriously the claim
that if there is experience there is
pre-reflective self-awareness not just
the enabling conditions for

pre-reflective self-awareness there is a
uh a subjective thickness a forness to
all experience uhhuh that that's that
that's the claim I'm making and I think
the notion of this uh pre-reflective
is the fact that it's enable it's note
it's not a pre- enabler of itself it's a
pre- enabler of higher order forms of
self-reflexivity yeah so it presupposes
the very capacity for that but in some
deflationary sense it's always there so
when you get your self- reflexivity
you've always got this sense that there
is but again when I say there is a sense
I don't mean a sense that you're
intending that it's just there that that
object is being intended for some one or
something okay

so let's just go through some examples
so

Darius has meditated and it has been
more or less okay and then he gets up
and he tries to do some walking
meditation uh on the lawn and then
something like a flow State happens and
you can tell your listeners what exactly
that implies lies suddenly the walking
becomes completely effortless mhm and in
a only attention is only in the present
moment um there are no noticeable
thoughts

um is that for whom this you're trying
to get up in that case is it something
like the for this bod

uh well in the sense of the walking
meditation I would say that the
subjectivity there is punctuated ultim
or defined ultimately by a certain

bodiliness not so much an embodiment but
in bodiliness there's a sort of bodily
thickness to the experience um yeah you
know so and is that that you feel your
guts and your
heartbeat no it's not I know no no I
wouldn't say it's as specific as that um
there might be some people you know anal
SE type might say well you always have
this um buzzing of in you know viscera
in you know and guts and the
interceptive processes for me so I think
there's an open question that I was
going to ask you actually and I guess I
have more questions more questions to
you now I want to understand this so in
being no one I I have also described
this special I've made these neurop
phenomenological case studies there are
these kotar syndrome patients who will
merely
sit in a chair and claim that they are
dead so they have no life no lived body
but a corpse and I will even ask the
doctors to throw that corpse
away in saying that there is a forness
still you think I I well it is you know
kotar syndrome kot's delusion it's it's
a I would I would I would I would
tentatively suggest that it's still a
delusion for whom in the same way as
realization um which you know to be
candid with everyone I have experienced
a fair bit of um as a result of anxiety
attacks and there is nonetheless a
Fess in a derealized or depersonalize
state okay more questions Darius has
been stoned out of his mind again but he

realizes he has to get home begins
walking home the body walks home home
while in a completely absentminded State
um is there where's the forness hiding
there so okay so I I think uh there is a
point here that I think I I I can't
answer currently which is whether
pre-reflective self-awareness is always
pre-reflective bodily self-awareness so
I think that's a that's a that's an
interesting question Darius is in
dreamless deep Sleep yeah is there
forness in dream is deep sleep no right
no I would say you're just Darius is non
lucidly dreaming is it for whus for the
subject for the phenomenal subject of my
dreaming experience I would hold that
there is a for whus within their
experience okay now Darius reads a
Buddhist trez and comes to the
conclusion forness is the root of all
suffering I must think about the most
efficient way to eliminate this what
would he
uh presumably I would probably start
doing some
vipasa um and or maybe take some maybe
take some DMT or something I don't know
uh blow my blow my neurons apart so you
would aim at what researchers called ego
dissolution and then I would which I'm
skeptical of I'm not saying I don't I'm
not again I haven't read your entire
book I I can't say yeah I'm I'm I'm
purely skeptical of
um this notion of I think I think
there's a little section of the flow
paper where we say okay there might be a

a range of flow states which include psychedelic and meditative states such that you get something like the downregulation of the default mode Network and the loss of reflective self-awareness right like planning is prohibited meta self-conceptualization is prohibited and I I I sense that in some of my own meditative experiences and psychedelic experiences and Flow State experiences for that matter nonetheless um I think what people I think there's a risk or a suspicion that when people are talking about ego dissolution there is nevertheless a maintenance of subjectivity in their experience maybe brings us back to the question you still wanted to ask I mean a big epistemological issue I have there's a one very good paper about it by Rafael Miler I flagged know how why should we believe any auto fine phenomenological report about ego dissolution well I was going to ask that so I was curious about you know how can you coherently report a self a state of consciousness from autobio your own autobiographical memory exactly so I see the issue there and there are some um attempts to get around it by saying autobiographical memory is constituted to a second order architecture but I think the somehow the claim somebody and that's the question the claims is making that they themselves were having a selfless experience during that period

of time and that cannot be right somehow
yes in some sense well yeah something's
G to miss there so the linguist
Exposition is somehow
faulty yeah if it was true this point
I'm flagging and on which I have no how
say no official final
opinion this is of course an epistem
epistemological barrier for doing
research on this because all people
reporting things like that we should
doubt them we should think yeah they had
a a near selfless State and their conf
fabula because they want to have
something so much you know they are
Buddhist Pious Buddhist Believers and
they want to report something they want
to report an
experience
but the the question could
be is there an unconscious
autobiographical
memory which was running and
registering you know while there was a
conscious selfless experience and which
afterwards surfaced again that was by
some unconscious mechanism that was a
selfless episode was
registered then is made globally
available again and then misdescribed by
somebody who just doesn't know what to
say about it and MISD describes it as
their own experience
um what would you yeah well I just I
wonder whether even an unconscious
memory doesn't in some
way
involve the self specifying process

that's a good point that's a very good point right so I it might not only be an issue of the intentional you know the intentions of the subject such that you know I want to deceive I want to confabulate I want I really want this to be true it may just be the very Act of a lived experience passing into memory transforms it yeah that's might be exactly right that in beings like us were as you said before self-specific mechanisms were so important from an evolutionary perspective also the retrieval process

automatically structures the whole thing in some egocentric self-specific format it brings exactly exactly so I've only got a couple other questions I'm aware of time constraints um yeah keep going I hear lunch isn't ready yet

so you you live a lovely life uh no it's tomorrow my term no there there's a there's a there's a slight mention again very early on in the book about uh intrinsic phenomenological essence of pure awareness so this kind of is there a unifying characteristic because in the book you sort of the structure in many ways is sort of the different features um of pure awareness so you have the kind of relaxation for example I believe is the first chapter and and there are others um do you what what's the kind of conclusion to that question about whether there's a intrinsic phenomenological Essence to Pure awareness well this is really just preliminary work it's it's more like

creating a platform for other people to start from but there's a summary chapter in which I I have tried to extract five different readings of what Purity could mean you know because also different people mean different things by it and I'm also this right at the beginning most meditators or um metaphysically minded people from India will hate what I'm saying my working hypothesis is that pure awareness is not pure um because it has a content right um and then the question the research question is what kind of content could be so simple and subtle that it makes it absolutely natural for people afterwards to say I experienced the character of awareness as such pwar what would that be and uh that's what I'm trying to answer so I don't believe I an anti-essentialist I don't think um you know this also metaphysically I don't do metaphysics but the whole idea of an intrinsic property which something processes in all possible contexts um I don't believe it I think there are only relational properties uh and only relational properties in the end also fit into the scientific scheme of explanation and knowing phenomena I think yeah so if there is as many claim an intrinsic Essence to awareness itself this would be a prime candidate for something that cannot be reductively explained by

science a prime candidate right yes it's
its own sort of prime mover unmoved to
you know go the way the way back to
Aristotle um I guess um when when I
think about um pure awareness I also
think about pure Consciousness events
Robert Foreman's work in the '80s um
and I got in I I've said this on the
podcast before but I got sort of
introduced to that by John Vu who I know
you've spoken to um and John describes
the way that foreman describes pure
Consciousness offense and I think in
quite a poetic and beautiful way again
in no ways uh do I mean poetic in any
derogatory manner that um adjectival
qualia is lost so
bless redness warmth and so on but
adverbial qualia remains and by that it
means presence nowness
heess potentially subjectivity I wanted
to pick up on one of them which was uh
ness or
presence um you write I think I mean
again these are the earlier works but
you write quite explicitly that
phenomenal States you know one of the
constraints of them is this presentness
um is it the
case that phenomenal State experiences
need to be experienced
now and if so what does that mean I mean
what does it Islander phenomenal
experience seemingly to emerge yet not
be distinct in some ways from the flow
of time yeah this is where of
course um we don't have any clear
intuitions so um

how to say my former research assistant
Jennifer Wind who has written this
fantastic book dreaming at M
press we have discussed a lot many years
ago oh what the step from MPS to MP
would be what one would have to subtract
from minimal phenomenal selfhood to
arrive at an even simpler form selfless
experience and you can see in her
comment on Evan Thompson in the publicly
available openm um
contribution that she thinks there
is an experience of pure D duration just
duration as such so that the lowest
level could be as you seem to imply some
sort of temporal
experience my intuition is
rather as the Tibetan Buddhists say
presentness is one of the three times you know
past presentness and
future pure awareness is timeless it
doesn't even have presentness or the mere
experience of duration it is an
experience of
timelessness and I think some of my
phenomenological data seem to point into
direction uh my intuition is also in
that direction
that there is timelessness that there
actually is phenomenology of
timelessness it does exist without
presentness but what I don't know is how to
get at this without just doing it
completely bottom up with the
Neuroscience of time representation you
know which I still don't think we really
know um no we don't
I I wrote this one paper actually it was

a kind of very well it's a lot shorter
than the flow paper bit it's an addendum
to the flow paper about um the the the
I'm trying to give a computational
mechanism underpinning the the flow of
time um uh using well kind of based off
jelian phenomenology so retention Primal
impression and yeah and so on um
whatever the last one is pretention um I
guess I guess footnote footnote I have
in
1995 edited a high octane collection
which is also collection which is also
available in English it's called
experience and um there is a paper in
there by German neuros psychologist EA
Runo and
mathematician um which is called time
gestal and the
Observer you may find that inspiring
just just a footnote time the Observer
should be in your library 199 oh my
library is expanding all the time
University Library I mean oh I see okay
well maybe maybe not um okay well before
we leave I'm just curious um you've been
writing for a long time um and it's a
very sort of marked and productive and
quite remarkable career and as I said I
feel like the the focus um change well
not changed but it has a certain
direction towards going beyond the basic
smt Theory and Beyond the minimal
phenomenal self to expand into epistemic
self models um and then almost like a
retreat back into pure awareness I'm
curious just throughout the whole you
know 93 up to

2024 I'm just yeah I guess I'm just
curious about what is there anything
you've changed your mind on is anything
that sort of convinced you like oh the
this part of the smt needs
tweaking
oh many things
uh uh I sometimes play this guy game
with myself is uh where was I really
firmly convinced of something and uh was
absolutely wrong um I give you three
examples and I can go to smt um the
first example is a German um
how do you say tabloid press always said
the terrorists of the Red Army fraction
are all hiding in East Germany in
Eastern Germany and I thought Ah that's
just total nonsense you know that's that
that's and that's where they caught them
after the war came uh F down second
thing is I thought it would be
absolutely impossible that everybody
stopped smoking I thought this would
lead to large scale Rebellion
and and it happened so my worldview was
completely wrong so now
scientifically there's a book that
fortunately never came out if you read
the ego
tunnel which I have um after some long
meditation courses in my 20s I had a few
outof body experiences which also led to
research and I was deeply shocked deeply
shocked because I thought my my God
because they were so realistic I thought
my God all this new age crap this this
total bizarre nonsense about the Astro
body and the subtle body it's literally

true and man I can't I can't talk to
anybody about this there's an immortal
soul and it can leave the
body you know uh completely
um and then I wrote to many people
Charles tart and Harvey Irving
and said we need to have the an edited
collection start research and outof body
experience and I still have no publisher
took it and it was very good because it
would have re ruined my academic career
at the outset but there was one woman
from England in there uh who and I hated
her contribution Sue
Blackmore oh yeah and then sue Blackmore
and her husband the late Tom Treno were
in Germany in tubing and she had this
you know um this this theory that those
were very special kind of hallucinations
and Illusions and I went down to tubing
and to straighten her out I I thought
she was you know it's totally crazy
because I had this super realistic
phenomenology and then she asked me um a
question so when you've say you've moved
out of your body and you've come to a
stand still beside the bed what do you
do then I said well maybe I go to the
window sill and and try to look out and
and she said so how do you do that do
you fly yeah or do do you walk step by
step I said
ah it's kind of inde defined I think of
wanting to go to the window sill and
look out of the window and I'm there and
she said okay what do you do next I said
well I'm I'm I'm I I I go to the light
switch to see if my fingers go through

or if I can turn on the light switch if
I'm only sleep say okay how do you get
there do you walk step by step or you
fly through the and I thought well it's
kind of I think of the light switch and
I'm there and she says see there are
discontinuities this is the cognitive L
map as one said at that time your brain
has of your bedroom and you're just
jumping from one Landmark point in your
internal representation uh of your
bedroom and between there is nothing and
that made me
think and now I
think many out of body experiences are
special kind of vestibular motor
hallucinations and I've done research on
it with friends a while
ago
and this I really changed my mind
I really changed my mind because this
was such an
indubitable realistic
phenomenology uh and and and Sue made me
see something I didn't see in my own
phenomenology I could go on no no no
it's a it's it's a good one um no it's
just making me think I mean one well
there are three things one is that I
hate to well I don't hate to but uh dor
has a really nice bit on out of body
experiences just for anyone who's I
don't know if you've ever come across
this 2010 paper I don't may not remember
I have to it's nice it's a nice paper
it's um myself with no body body
body very good name um so that's one
thing and then I guess a more well I

guess a more pertinent question to the actual experience itself was you know I spoke about how sometimes I feel that when I read phenomenology I'm being duped into recognizing in my own phenomenology a phenomenological supposed fact that the writer is uh put on the page so dor was say okay in out of body experiences you always have a sense of a bodily self that's intending the objects of the experience like oh of course I mean not I've ever had one but I can imagine like oh of course I can imagine what that's like and I can imagine I'm not saying it happened I can imagine that I would have had I you know like in your case I would have an out of body experience and someone goes yeah but it was discontinuous and I go oh yeah of course it was and in and I'm again being duped into uh through some nice and I'm not accusing Sue of having an agenda or anything but I'm being duped by the questioning into Because the actual memory the kind of engram is so fuzzy because it's you know it's a I can imagine they are it you the mind is wanting to take on any you know rigid form of experience that can be labeled okay it was discontinuous did you ever reflect on that and go am I 100% sure that her description is reflecting my phenomen uh my phenomenological experience and also how do you contend with that generally one can if one looks at this in the f one can go on for

instance predictive processing assumes

there are

prior one stable prior I had is it is

pitch black dark night and there is no

light in my bedroom

I wouldn't expect anything to see

anything on the way to the window sill

where there was maybe a little light

outside you know and I would expect

total phenomenal indeterminacy on the

trajectory there uh what does it really

mean you know uh one can always doubt

and come back uh

and but what I mean this was really an

example of how a body body bodily

sensation structured an environment yeah

you know very

clearly

and footnote um there are rare

cases I've said it I think in one of the

Mind wandering papers of aromatic body

out of body first thing one has to

understand there are very different

kinds of body outof body

experiences one you might have in a wake

up phase of a catamin um after surgery

may be very different from what uh Yogi

in his cave in the Himalaya has you know

one you have after an accident uh may be

different from one you have on a

Meditation Retreat they are very

different and there are some people I

mean I've read all that literature at

the in the olden days because I was so

fascinated with it there are situations

where people just

experience themselves as an

extensionless point from which they view

scene and that's a borderline case of
embodiment I think one would say okay
but if you're still spatially located if
your visual perspective is located at
some point in space above your body
embodiment yeah yeah one could also
[Music]

say is that what we meant by a lived
body you know
the origin of a visual
perspective and we don't have a lot of
data
there yeah I mean in some ways I guess
it was um at the heart of your or you
know that's the heart of the original
definition of the MPS was that it is
spatially temporally centered on the
body this is yes of course of course and
we I think an important distinction we
made is and that has to do with your
interest in egocentric uh in
self-specific process
uh you can have an
egocentric body
centered spatial spacial visual spatial
model of reality that has a
center but not a firstperson perspective
in the epistemic sense that can be
dissociated I think um
and this is something you would want to
doubt that
anybody can have an egocentric model of
reality without a know knowing
self um I think it depends on what one
means by
epistemicity like is
it is it purely a intentional
relation um and we haven't even really

touched upon this because there's um I I
I kind of for actually many ways it
started off as a rhetorical decision a
clarifying decision like distinguish
between an epistemic agent model and
epistemic self model in this flow States
paper yeah and I and and I've been
thinking about why I did that and one is
because I think I was using the term
epistemic agency to describe something
like autonotic Consciousness so this
sense of uh pre-reflectively driving
yourself through time and I think that
that's C that's pretty nicely written
about phenomenologically and in the
cognitive science and people like um
wheeler and there's a whole literature
on autonotic Consciousness that was
very rich but I guess the other reason
why I thought that is I thought I I've
explicitly said now in the paper that uh
I'm taking
epistemic self models to be a or I'm Tak
taking epistemic agent models to be a
subset of epistemic self models yeah I
think and the reason why I say that is
because I think there are moments of the
sense of epistemic selfhood which don't
require an AG an agent yeah yeah but but
it's interesting because um in your work
you kind you you you know when you
introduce the notion of an epistemic
agent model was an epistemic agent
model
so do you think that um very interesting
let me ask a question I know what you
mean so um see say somebody sits on
their cushion and does a meditation

technique that scientists called open monitoring so tries to kind of effortlessly non agentively be with the whole phenomenal field not a meditation object but everything Y and um has we also assume in a thoughtless state so there's wakefulness no agentive Precision control attention whatsoever but there is an awareness of the whole thing and no thought no verification is that maybe the how say the prime candidate of the forness you're thinking about would you say that this is still for the person sitting on their cushion I would I mean I would even go beyond that and say that this is uh invol it goes even beyond the minimal phenomenal subjectivity such that involve some epistemicity such that there's a KN and I think this is important I mean I I guess the question I was also going to ask is what do we mean when we talk about the sense of a knowing self is it a knowing self that uh is agentically or agentively knowing such that it's purposefully seems to be purposefully driving itself towards some knowledge some relationship with the world or is it a um or can we disambiguate those two things so I think a canonical example here is mind wandering um I've propose I mean it's a footnote it's not

particularly relevant to the question of
flow but it's just in terms of getting
the terminology really fixed I propose
that mind wandering is an example of uh
it's an Associated feature of an
epistemic self model but not an
epistemic agent model

ah because I think you can daydream
about an epis indeed indeed it it gets
complex at different kinds of things but
um so um if

you read

the introduction to the open mind
collection Jenny wind and I have coined
the term the phenomenal signature of
knowing and we were writing about
intuitions and why one should do
um empirically oriented philosophy of
mind without intuition mongering as we
call it so we think there is a
phenomenal signature of knowing for
instance if you have an intuition you
just have this feeling I just know this
but you don't know where that knowledge
comes from now what I think this new
work shows is that there can be an
uncontracted phenomenal signature of
knowing human brains are capable of this
yes this the

poor maybe Carl would have a completely
deflationary reading of this you you
know just that the the overall certainty
or Pro probability with associated with
the whole model

if that is true this might be very close
to what Consciousness is and it might
also be close to what you are trying to
find out right is isn't that it an a a

phenomenal signature of knowing that is not contracted into an agent or a self is that what you mean well I guess the question is well in some sense but I guess the question therefore is could you have a minimal phenomenal self without uh without it becoming an epistemic self model yeah you can of course you can but then but then in some sense that that then the knowing the signature of knowing would not be at the heart of Consciousness because you would have a paradigmatic case of Consciousness without the sense of knowing well if it is basically the bodily here and now which is a very common the Here and Now is a very common meditation experience it be that the presence of a signature of knowing kind of falls out of it or naturally reveals it in in that kind of state of just being no would it be would it be a necessary concomitant could you imagine that there is a pure here there's a bit where I talk about again this is just I I think actually I'm just going to point people in the direction of the paper because I have really thought about this and I guess it's not been in explicit terms in like a conversation like this but it's just been trying to demarcate these categories um that I don't think the distinction between the uh I take the minimal phenomenal self here to just be identical to what I've been calling pre-reflective self-awareness I know the ontological commitments are different

but it was just easier um and I make
that clear but I I make it very clear
therefore that I don't think that um
there's a strict distinction between an
epistemic self model and a phen minimal
phenomenal self because a minimal
phenomenal self can have this signature
of knowing as you said um but it makes
me wonder whether you can have like is
that signature of knowing an add-on a
build you know an extra layer to Pure
subjectivity or is it imminent in the
subjectivity I can I do not know uh I
can only share with you the way I'm
trying to frame it

now a living organism with a nervous
system opens an epistemic space um and
this epistemic space can maybe even
extend across the boundaries of the body
and some kinds of active inference and
so on and so

forth but an organism is only conscious
I think the essence of being conscious
is to have a model of that space to know
that you many ways to tell this to know
that you are an embodied epistemic
space and this significance of pure
awareness experiences and like this is
that you can well you can stabilize the
model of your own epistemic space
and it's not transparent anymore it
becomes opaque you can notice it and
become aware of it um that's that's part
of the interesting thing so I would say
there's a space in that space many
different epistemic uh Poss uh states
can happen in our own case most of them
coded as properties of a knowing self

that knows but that's not a necessary
condition some systems in some
situations can model the space as such
in an uncentered way and then you get
this pure signature of knowing I mean
you maybe you would find there's a
chapter on witness Consciousness maybe
You' find that helpness helpful um I
don't I don't know that's how the way
I'm trying to frame this
so a patient
in vegetative coma in unresponsive
wakefulness
syndrome
certainly has an epistemic space it
knows how to breathe how not to die
there are gaze following movements and
stuff like this but it's entirely
unconscious because it has no model of
its own epistemic space the organism
doesn't
know that it has up opened an epistemic
space same thing when you wake up in the
morning I
claim that most people know what pure
awareness is but never pay attention to
it it may be the first 200 300 500
milliseconds of the waking up process in
morning where you come to but you don't
know who you are you don't know where
you are you don't know what place you
are in you're disoriented to place time
and person as a psychiatrist would be
but Wide Awake that is the system which
you are is just booting its model of the
epistemic
base and a second later you know there
will be the bedroom and it will be

filled with content but the in the budha
process there's a short period where
there is just a model of wakefulness per
se of becoming epistemically open to the
world that's how I would like to or try
to frame it but I don't know if it's
correct no well it sounds well in my
experience there's certainly that um
that that that chimes with my intuitions
or at least you know my fake
Recollections of that I mean I think you
also get that sometimes where you wake
up from a very deep you know not even in
the morning I mean I think actually you
get a more protracted experience of that
sometimes in the middle in is that the
two first 200 milliseconds is there
forness the thing you're trying to get
after I still kind I still think there
is but is has anyone done any
qualitative work on
this on the first few seconds well I
think don't know what um just for the
audience and for myself actually what
you know the one where you talked about
the pure signature of knowing do you
recall which the name of that paper yeah
it's freely away aivable in the internet
uh it's open minus mind net the open
mind collection and it's in the
introduction it's in an introduction you
can download it oh what does it mean to
have an open mind excellent lovely
yeah I think I have to have lunch now no
have lunch didn't you know what we
didn't even touch upon the PMI R but I
think that's for part two um we were
touching upon it then but it's for

another time I cuz I've got a slight
I've got a slight thing to pick with the
PMI but I'm not going to get into it now
because you've got lunch um Thomas yeah
I'm going to need a nap lunch a bath I
don't know what I'm going to need to do
this I'm GNA need to take a moment but
this was tremendous fun I mean it was
tremendous fun for me I really hope
everyone it's you know your work is just
so terrific the depth the Lucidity
tackling really I think probably the
most fundamental questions that there
are um in a astute robust way is like it
it really is something quite incredible
so thank you so much for taking the time
uh to speak to me was very nice talking
to you the elephant and the blind is out
now so people should pick that up and
read it and as you say it's open access
um I always like to just give people a
minute at the end just to speak about
anything else that they've got going on
slash where people can find them um you
know email wise Twitter whatever you
want well I have an an Old English
website at the University of Minds which
you can find through Wikipedia page
trying to build a new one doesn't
doesn't work
um I don't know the most important thing
for me at this stage is that I've just
worked very hard for 40 years I'm now
retired and I really don't want to work
hard
anymore congratulations and you might
want to is any anything you want to say
about the foundation or the competition

that's currently open anything like that
yeah maybe you you want to post this um
if you're interested in the MP project
there's a a website now MP minus
pro.info and you find a lot of stuff and
material there and there's a
price that with British scientists uh
like Carl and anneal uh in the in the
jury and by 31st of September we look
for um formal models for the
computational phenomenology of MP of
pure awareness so if anybody wants to
win 20,000
Euros look at that come on guys yeah
yeah I'm I'm I'm still thinking I'm
still thinking I I got to read the book
first um completely again
so much fun so much gratitude um thank
you so much again for me and The
Institute uh it's been a real pleasure
same here uh good luck with it all
thanks thas thanks great